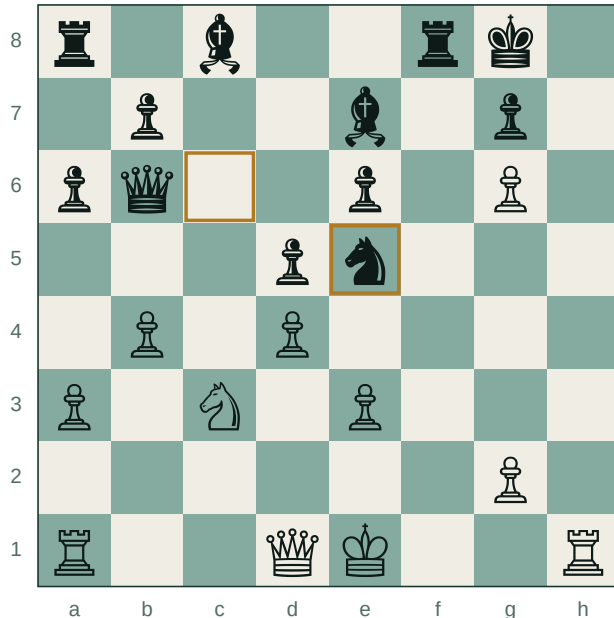


Mate in three: White, move 18

Mate in three

White to move



Previous move: 17...Nxe5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

18. Rh8+ Kxh8 19. Qh5+ Kg8 20. Qh7#

18.Rh8+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. Recorded reply: **18...Kxh8**.

19.Qh5+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. From h5 it attacks king on h8 and knight on e5. Recorded reply: **19...Kg8**.

20.Qh7# Mate: queen on h7 gives check; Black has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on g8. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Queen on h7. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not stop at a promising check. The final mating position must still be legal after every intervening move.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Longer mating lines require accurate visualization. Track the king's square, opened lines, and every sacrificed piece through the entire sequence.

HOW TO LOOK

Work backward from a mating pattern, then calculate forward with the opponent choosing the strongest defense.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: rook on a8 and bishop on e7. Check for tactical protection.